STANDARD OPERATING PROCEDURE · OWNER EDITION

Invoice Processing System

How to run your automated accounts payable day to day: approve large invoices, clear the review list, and respond to alerts. About **10 minutes a week** for a typical small business.

Version 1.0 · 1 Oct 2026 | For: business owner / approver | No technical skills needed

Demo edition prepared for Brightside Creative Studio (fictional). Vendors, amounts and email addresses are test data. Prepared by Khael Mendoza · KhaelWorks.

1 · WHAT THE SYSTEM DOES FOR YOU

It reads, checks, files and logs every invoice. You only decide.

The system does

- Picks up invoices from email or the upload form
- Reads vendor, invoice number, dates and amounts
- Re-adds the math and checks the dates
- Blocks invoices you have already received
- Files every PDF in Google Drive
- Records every invoice in the **Invoice Register** sheet

You still do

- Approve or reject invoices **over $500**
- Resolve invoices sent to **Needs Review**
- Pay vendors from your bank or accounting tool, as today
- Act on an alert email if one ever arrives

> **The system never pays anyone.** It gives you a checked, approved list. Money only moves when you pay it.

2 · YOUR ROUTINE AT A GLANCE

Four tasks, most of them take a minute

WHEN	TASK	TIME	PROCEDURE
As emails arrive	Approve or reject invoices over $500	~1 min each	SOP-01
Weekly (e.g. Friday)	Clear the Needs Review list	~5 min	SOP-02
Weekly (current setup)	Re-confirm the Google sign-in	~2 min	SOP-04
Only if one arrives	Respond to an alert email	~5 min	SOP-03
Anytime	Find an invoice or its PDF	<1 min	SOP-05

3 · HOW INVOICES GET IN

Two doors in, one process

DOOR	WHO USES IT	RULE
Email	Vendors, or staff forwarding a bill	Send to the company inbox. The subject must contain the word **invoice** and a **PDF must be attached**. Checked every minute.
Upload form	Staff with a PDF in hand	Open `[your invoice form link]`, attach the PDF, enter your email, add an optional note, submit.

Tip: ask regular vendors to put "Invoice" and their invoice number in the email subject. Emails without a PDF attachment, or without "invoice" in the subject, are ignored on purpose so normal mail is never processed.

4 · PROCEDURES

Step-by-step

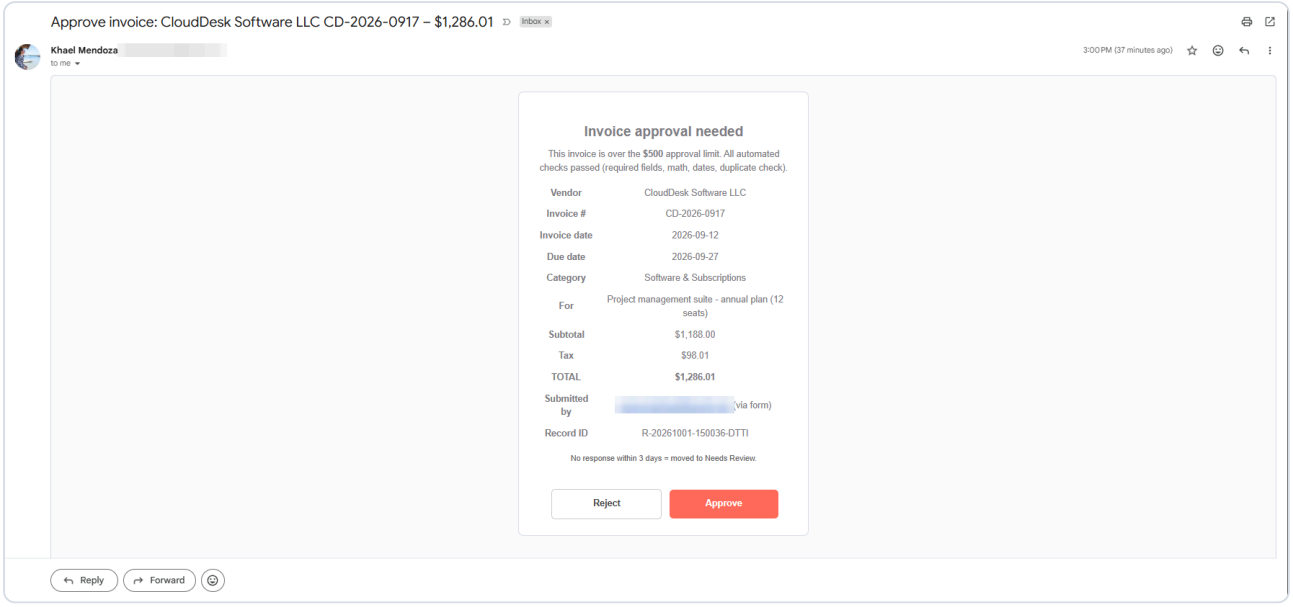
SOP-01 · Approve or reject an invoice over $500

AS EMAILS ARRIVE

1. Open the email titled **"Approve invoice: [Vendor] [Invoice #] – $[Total]"**.
2. Check the table: vendor, invoice number, dates, what it is for, subtotal, tax and total. The math and duplicate checks have already passed.
3. Click **Approve** to accept it, or **Reject** if it should not be paid. A confirmation page opens in your browser.
4. Pay approved invoices through your usual bank or accounting tool.

✓ **Done when:** The Register row shows Approved or Rejected, your email, and the time you clicked. The PDF moves to Processed (approved) or Needs Review (rejected).

No answer within 3 days: the invoice moves to Needs Review with the note "Approval request timed out after 3 days". Each email can be answered once.



The approval email. One click records the decision, the approver and the time.

SOP-02 · Clear the Needs Review list

WEEKLY

1. Open the **Invoice Register** sheet. Click the **status** column header → **Data › Create a filter** → filter to **Needs Review**.
2. For each row, read the **notes** column and open the PDF from **drive_file_url**.
3. Do what the table below says for that reason.
4. When the vendor sends a corrected invoice, submit it through the form or email as normal. A flagged, rejected or duplicate row never blocks a corrected resubmission.

NOTE SAYS	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT TO DO
Math error: subtotal + tax = X, but invoice total is Y	The vendor's total does not add up	Ask the vendor for a corrected invoice. Do not pay the printed total.
Missing invoice number / date / total	A required detail is not printed	Ask the vendor to reissue with the missing detail.
Invoice date is in the future / over a year old	The date looks wrong	Confirm the date with the vendor; resubmit the corrected invoice.
No readable text (likely a scanned/image PDF)	A photo or scan; the system cannot read it	Ask the vendor for a digital PDF, or record it manually.
Rejected by approver	You clicked Reject	Nothing, unless you change your mind (then resubmit).
Approval request timed out after 3 days	No one clicked	Resubmit the invoice to get a fresh approval email.
Unexpected currency	Not in USD	Check with the vendor; process manually.

Duplicates have status **Duplicate** (not Needs Review) and a note naming the original record. Usually a vendor "reminder" for an invoice you already have: no action needed beyond replying to the vendor.

✓ **Done when:** Every Needs Review row has been answered or resubmitted.

SOP-03 · When an alert email arrives

ONLY IF ONE ARRIVES

Subject: **"⚠️ Invoice automation failed at [step name]"**. It means one invoice may not have been processed. Nothing is lost: the original email or form submission still exists.

1. Read the **Likely fix** line in the alert. The most common one is an expired Google sign-in (do SOP-04).
2. If the fix is unclear, forward the alert to your VA / automation support. It contains everything they need.
3. After the fix, the failed run can be retried from the link in the alert (your VA can do this), or simply resubmit the invoice.

✓ **Done when:** The invoice appears in the Register.

SOP-04 · Re-confirm the Google sign-in

WEEKLY · CURRENT SETUP

In the current setup Google asks the system to sign in again about every 7 days. This step disappears once the Google app is published (planned upgrade).

1. Open n8n → **Overview** → **Credentials**.
2. Open **Gmail (Invoice Automation)** → click **Sign in with Google** → choose the company account → **Continue** → tick all boxes → **Continue**.
3. Repeat for **Google Sheets (Invoice Automation)** and **Google Drive (Invoice Automation)**.

✓ **Done when:** Each credential shows a green "Account connected" banner.

SOP-05 · Find an invoice or its PDF

ANYTIME

1. Open the Invoice Register and press **Ctrl+F**. Search by vendor name or invoice number.
2. Click the link in **drive_file_url** to open the original PDF.

PDFs are named `date_Vendor_InvoiceNumber.pdf` (e.g. `2026-09-12_CloudDesk-Software-LLC_CD-2026-0917.pdf`), so the Drive folders also sort by date. Approved invoices are in **Processed**; everything else is in **Needs Review**, marked REJECTED, DUPLICATE, NO-NUMBER or REVIEW in the name.



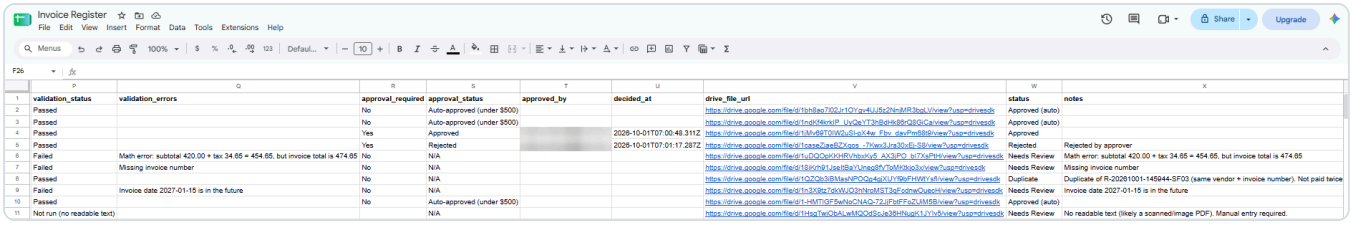
The Needs Review folder. The file name tells you why each invoice is there.

5 · READING THE INVOICE REGISTER

One row per invoice, whatever happened to it

STATUS	MEANING	PAY IT?	PDF FOLDER
`Approved (auto)`	Passed all checks, $500 or less	Yes	Processed
`Approved`	Over $500; you clicked Approve	Yes	Processed
`Rejected`	You clicked Reject	No	Needs Review
`Needs Review`	Failed a check, scanned, or approval timed out	Not yet	Needs Review
`Duplicate`	Same vendor + invoice number already received	No (already handled)	Needs Review

Most useful columns: **vendor_name**, **invoice_number**, **due_date**, **total**, **category**, **status**, **approved_by**, **decided_at**, **drive_file_url**, **notes**. Tip: filter **status** to Approved + Approved (auto) and sort by **due_date** for this week's payment run.



	P	Q	R	S	T	U	V	W	X
1	validation_status	validation_errors	approval_required	approval_status	approved_by	decided_at	drive_file_url	status	notes
2	Passed		No	Auto-approved (under $500)			https://drive.google.com/file/d/1bh8ap7l2JrlOYqv4UJ5z2NnMR3bpLV/view?usp=drivesdk	Approved (auto)	
3	Passed		No	Auto-approved (under $500)			https://drive.google.com/file/d/1ndKf4krkjP_UvQeYT3nBdHk88nQBGlCa/view?usp=drivesdk	Approved (auto)	
4	Passed		Yes	Approved		2026-10-01T07:00:49.311Z	https://drive.google.com/file/d/1dMv69T0tW2uSI-pX14w_Fbv_dexPm68R/view?usp=drivesdk	Approved	
5	Passed		Yes	Rejected		2026-10-01T07:01:17.287Z	https://drive.google.com/file/d/1oaseZoeBlZXqpq_-75kwJUa3DsEc9Bl/view?usp=drivesdk	Rejected	Rejected by approver
6	Failed	Math error: subtotal 420.00 + tax 34.65 = 454.65, but invoice total is 474.65	No	N/A			https://drive.google.com/file/d/1uDQOpKXHRVhbxKv5_AX3iPO_bI7XaPtH/view?usp=drivesdk	Needs Review	Math error: subtotal 420.00 + tax 34.65 = 454.65, but invoice total is 474.65
7	Failed	Missing invoice number	No	N/A			https://drive.google.com/file/d/18lKrh91JseltBaYUneq8fV7bMKbko3x/view?usp=drivesdk	Needs Review	Missing invoice number
8	Passed		No	N/A			https://drive.google.com/file/d/1Q2Qb3iBMasNPOQg4qXUY9bFHWtYa5/view?usp=drivesdk	Duplicate	Duplicate of R-20261001-145944-SF03 (same vendor + invoice number). Not paid twice.
9	Failed	Invoice date 2027-01-15 is in the future	No	N/A			https://drive.google.com/file/d/1n3X9tz7dkWJO3hNn9MST3oFpdnwQuec4/view?usp=drivesdk	Needs Review	Invoice date 2027-01-15 is in the future
10	Passed		No	Auto-approved (under $500)			https://drive.google.com/file/d/1-HMTI0F5wNsCNAQ-72JJFtrFFuZUMf5B/view?usp=drivesdk	Approved (auto)	
11	Not run (no readable text)			N/A			https://drive.google.com/file/d/1Hsq7wiObfLwMQOdSoJe3RHNqzK1JYlv5/view?usp=drivesdk	Needs Review	No readable text (likely a scanned/image PDF). Manual entry required.

The Invoice Register: status, approver, time and a link to every PDF.

6 · DO AND DON'T

Keep these the same so the system keeps working

Please don't

- Rename or reorder the **header row** of the Register
- Delete rows of approved invoices (the duplicate check reads them)
- Move or delete the **Processed** and **Needs Review** folders
- Delete the Gmail label `invoice-processed`
- Edit the workflow in n8n yourself

Fine to do

- Add filters, colours or your own columns to the **right of the last column**
- Rename the sheet tab
- Move PDFs out of Drive after they are paid, if you keep the Register link history elsewhere
- Forward vendor invoices to the inbox with "Invoice" in the subject

7 · CHANGING A RULE

Send a change request to your VA

YOU WANT TO	TELL YOUR VA
Change the approval limit	The new amount (e.g. "approve over $1,000")
Change or add an approver	Their email address
Add or rename expense categories	The full list you want
Accept another currency	The currency code (e.g. PHP)
Process emails from a different inbox	The inbox address

Each change is tested with one invoice before it goes live.

8 · TROUBLESHOOTING

If something looks off

YOU NOTICE	MOST LIKELY CAUSE	DO THIS
An emailed invoice never appeared in the Register	Subject lacks "invoice", or no PDF attached	Forward it again with "Invoice" in the subject, or use the upload form
No approval email for a big invoice	Check spam; or the invoice failed a check	Look it up in the Register (SOP-05) and read the notes
Clicking Approve shows an error page	Already answered, or past 3 days	Check the Register row; resubmit if it timed out
Alert says Google sign-in expired	Weekly sign-in due	SOP-04
Notes say "Drive upload failed – PDF not filed"	Temporary Google Drive issue	Download the original from the email/form and save it to the folder; tell your VA
Nothing processed for a day or more	Workflow switched off or server down	Contact your VA

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